RESEARCH FRAMEWORK / MARKET

Market Landscape

A practical framework for defining a market, organising customer segments, and documenting opportunity questions without implying unsupported market size.

01 Executive summary

A commissioned report would summarise the decision being considered, the scope examined, the most relevant evidence-backed observations, the main uncertainties, and the next decision points.

This illustrative document demonstrates a summary format only. It does not report actual market findings, verified organisations, client results, or recommendations about a real business.

* Decision question and intended audience
* Scope and evidence base reviewed
* Key observations with confidence and limitations
* Prioritised areas for further consideration

02 Illustrative research question

How should a business structure an initial assessment of an unfamiliar market before deciding whether to invest in a deeper study?

03 Hypothetical context

Hypothetical demonstration: an unnamed B2B service business is considering whether to explore a new customer segment. No company, geography, market result, or customer behaviour is represented as real.

DEMONSTRATION ONLY

No actual findings, clients, or sources are presented.

04 Scope and methodology

A live engagement would state the agreed market or organisation boundaries, geographic coverage, time period, included and excluded questions, source types, and analytical approach.

Research steps should be proportionate to the decision and evidence available. This demonstration describes a possible report structure, not research performed against real organisations or sources.

* Research question and decision context
* Scope, inclusion criteria, and exclusions
* Public and client-supplied evidence distinguished
* Review period and analysis approach

05 Findings and analysis

A completed report would distinguish observed information from analyst interpretation and hypotheses. Each material finding would be connected to evidence and assessed against the agreed question.

No real findings, comparisons, scores, market sizes, or business outcomes are asserted in this illustrative sample.

* Observed evidence and its source
* Interpretation and relevance to the decision
* Counter-signals, confidence, and open questions
* No unsupported statistics or inferred private performance

06 Evidence and source notes

For a real research engagement, a source log can record the publisher, title, publication date, retrieval date, URL or document reference, geographic coverage, relevant claim, and known limitations.

This demonstration intentionally does not cite external sources or present its example material as verified evidence.

* Publisher and source title
* Publication and retrieval dates
* URL or document reference and supported claim
* Source quality, coverage, and known limitations

07 Limitations and uncertainties

A research report should explain information gaps, source coverage, recency, conflicting claims, assumptions, and areas requiring further validation.

This illustrative document cannot establish actual demand, market size, competitor performance, partner willingness, or future results.

* Evidence gaps and unverified assumptions
* Source and geographic coverage
* Areas where additional research may be appropriate
* No guarantee of commercial or operational outcomes

08 Recommendations

Recommendations in a live report should follow from documented evidence and the agreed decision criteria. Their rationale, dependencies, and uncertainties should remain visible.

No real-world recommendations or outcomes are claimed in this illustrative document.

* Prioritised recommendations tied to the research question
* Evidence rationale and uncertainty for each action
* Dependencies, owners, or timing only where agreed

09 Proposed next steps

Potential next steps may include gathering additional evidence, testing a defined hypothesis, consulting relevant specialists, or reviewing specified indicators.

A live engagement would agree responsibilities, timing, and review points with the client. This demonstration does not claim that any action has been taken or that an outcome is assured.

* Identify the most important unresolved question
* Agree what additional evidence would help answer it
* Set proportionate review points and decision criteria
* Revisit conclusions as relevant evidence changes

10 Decision brief and scope

Begin with the decision the research is expected to inform, the current alternatives, and the time horizon. State what is outside the brief so that a broad market question does not become an unbounded research task.

Define the working market boundary by customer type, need or job-to-be-done, offer category, geography, and relevant time period. Treat each boundary as a scope choice to be confirmed with the commissioning team.

* Decision owner and decision date
* Customer groups and use cases to examine
* Geographic coverage and language
* Out-of-scope segments and questions

11 Segmentation hypotheses

Develop candidate segments as hypotheses rather than asserted market facts. Useful segmentation dimensions may include organisation size, sector, procurement context, maturity, or urgency of need, depending on the brief.

For each segment, record why it may matter, what observable evidence could test the hypothesis, and what information is missing. Do not assign unsupported segment sizes or demand scores.

* Hypothesis and rationale
* Evidence that could support or challenge it
* Information gaps and confidence limits
* Potential interview or validation questions

12 Evidence register and source evaluation

Create a source register that records publisher, title, publication date, retrieval date, URL or document reference, geographic coverage, and the claim the source can support.

Separate direct observations from interpretation. Consider source incentives, methodology, recency, scope, and whether an independent source corroborates material claims. A published estimate is not automatically a verified market fact.

* Attributable public sources selected for the scope
* Client-provided context clearly identified as supplied information
* Source-level limitations and conflicts
* Claims requiring confirmation before decision use

13 Analytical structure

Compare segment hypotheses against agreed decision criteria such as strategic fit, accessibility of evidence, operational requirements, and unresolved assumptions. Use qualitative assessment unless defensible quantitative inputs are available.

When comparing alternatives, document the criteria and rationale. Avoid rankings or composite scores that imply measurement precision not present in the evidence.

* Market boundary and category definitions
* Segment comparison against agreed criteria
* Signals, counter-signals, and evidence gaps
* Decision implications and follow-up research

14 Illustrative synthesis format

A report can present a concise landscape map, a segment hypothesis table, evidence notes, and a short list of questions for further validation. This demonstration intentionally contains no market-size figures, real findings, or external sources.

Any eventual conclusion should state which evidence supports it, which assumptions remain untested, and what would change the interpretation.

* What the available evidence does and does not indicate
* Which hypotheses remain open
* What additional evidence is proportionate
* Which decision options could be considered

15 Limitations and potential outputs

Public information can be incomplete, inconsistent, commercially biased, or out of date. The sample framework cannot establish actual demand, market size, purchase intent, or commercial performance.

Potential outputs include a market landscape, segment hypothesis register, evidence log, scope notes, and prioritised recommendations for validation. Deliverables are agreed before an engagement begins.

* No exhaustive market sizing is implied
* No forecast or outcome guarantee
* Source quality and coverage are stated
* Further primary research may be separately scoped